

Team Start Right

LAW LINK



From Confusion to Connection

 Law Link

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FREE STUDENT LEGAL ADVICE

Your rights. Simply free.

Law Link connects you in minutes with the right student law clinic: AI-powered, location-aware, and completely free of charge.

[Describe my situation >](#)

[See past cases](#)

✓ Free for clients ✓ No account required ✓ Takes 2 minutes

64

law clinics across
Germany

100%

free legal advice

AI-
powered

intelligent
matching

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SR

sust^{ai}nability

1.Introduction

Access to free legal support remains challenging for many people, not because legal services are unavailable, but because finding the right support is often confusing. Student law clinics in Germany provide free legal assistance under the supervision of qualified lawyers and focus on specific legal areas and target groups, offering an important pathway to justice for individuals and nonprofit organizations (Law&Legal; Pro Bono Deutschland).

This project addresses the challenge proposed by Start Right e.V., a Munich-based student-run pro bono legal consultancy and member of Law Clinics Deutschland. Start Right supports nonprofit initiatives and social enterprises by providing free legal guidance under the supervision of experienced lawyers (Pro Bono Allianz; Start Right).



Figure 1. Overview of the proposed LawLink platform.

The central challenge is improving access to legal support. Potential users often struggle to identify the legal category of their issue, determine which law clinic can help, or understand whether they meet the clinic's eligibility requirements. At the same time, law clinics operate independently with different legal specializations, languages, capacities, and consultation requirements, making referrals complex.

To address this challenge, Team LawLink proposes an AI-assisted digital platform that guides users through natural-language questions and matches them with the most suitable law clinic based on legal issue, location, language, and eligibility. Rather than providing legal advice, LawLink functions as a referral and navigation platform. The concept also considers responsible AI, user privacy, and compliance with the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) to ensure transparency and trust throughout the referral process (European Commission).

Challenge Giver	Start Right e.V.
Project	Law Link
Goal	Simplify access to student law clinics
Approach	AI-assisted referral platform
Outcome	Better access to legal support

2. Problem Analysis

The problem LawLink addresses is not simply the absence of free legal support, but the difficulty of finding the right support at the right time. Student law clinics in Germany already provide an important access point for people and nonprofit organisations that cannot easily afford legal advice. However, this support is fragmented across different clinics, legal fields, eligibility rules and local procedures. For potential users, the first barrier is often not a legal argument itself, but the uncertainty of where to start. Many users do not know whether their problem belongs to housing, migration, employment, association law, consumer law or another legal area. They may also be unfamiliar with the concept of student law clinics or pro bono legal consultation. As access-to-justice research shows, legal problems are often experienced first as everyday social, financial or administrative problems, and people may not immediately recognise them as issues for which legal help is available.

This challenge is complex because legal triage depends on several changing factors at once. A suitable law clinic is not determined only by the topic of the case. Location, language, target group, urgency, claim amount, court representation, documentation requirements and the current capacity of the clinic can all affect whether a user can actually receive help. From the perspective of law clinics, referral work is also demanding because clinics are often run by volunteers with limited time and changing availability. If information about a clinic's active legal fields, intake process or exclusions is outdated, users may be sent to the wrong place, and clinics may receive requests they cannot handle. Research on legal aid intake similarly shows that eligibility criteria are nuanced, frequently revised and difficult to automate with simple static forms.

The problem has not been fully solved before because it is both an information problem and a trust problem. A simple directory of law clinics is useful, but it still assumes that users can correctly classify their own legal issue and compare different clinic conditions. This expectation is unrealistic for many people, especially users with limited legal literacy, limited German language skills, or previous negative experiences with institutions. Legal consciousness research suggests that migration background, social relations, cultural expectations and public policy can shape whether people understand law as accessible, risky, bureaucratic or useful. Therefore, a referral platform must not only "match" users technically; it must also explain what student law clinics are, what they can and cannot do, and what happens to the user's information.

The affected user groups include individuals who face legal uncertainty but lack the financial, linguistic or institutional resources to navigate the system alone, such as students, migrants, tenants, low-income residents, seniors and people dealing with administrative or employment problems. Nonprofit founders and social initiatives are also affected, because they may need legal orientation on association structures, incorporation or governance but may not know which specialised service fits their situation. The stakeholders are broader than the end users: Start Right, other student law clinics, Law Clinics Deutschland, supervising lawyers, universities, NGOs and community organisations are all involved in the referral ecosystem. Poor matching wastes volunteer capacity, delays access to help and can reduce trust in free legal support services.

3.Solution Development

Germany has over 64 student law clinics offering free legal advice supervised by licensed attorneys, yet the people who need this help most students, immigrants, tenants, refugees, and low-income residents frequently never reach the right one.

Through our initial research and a feedback session with challenge giver Florian Zeller of Start Right, three structural gaps became clear. Clients have no reliable way to identify which clinic covers their issue or whether they are eligible, clinics routinely receive misrouted requests and manage referrals between themselves manually with no shared digital infrastructure and when clinics close or change scope, there is no mechanism to notify clients. As Florian noted, what differentiates law clinics is the kind of issues they handle and the cases they are willing to take on, a distinction that is currently invisible to those who need help most.

Law Link is our response. It is a guided, AI-powered web platform that matches people with legal problems to the right student law clinic in minutes, in plain language, with no prior legal knowledge required. Unlike existing clinic websites, which are purely informational, Law Link actively classifies a user's situation, asks adaptive follow-up questions tailored to what the user has described not generic eligibility questions. We filter by location, eligibility and route the request directly to the matched clinic. It also provides the organisational layer no individual clinic website has, which is a shared referral framework that automatically reroutes cases between clinics when one cannot take them on and keeps users informed throughout.

The platform guides users through five stages and sets clear expectations upfront. Users describe their legal situation in plain language. AI classifies the legal area, generates targeted follow-up questions specific to what has been described, checks eligibility, and filters by location converging on a single best-fit clinic with a clear explanation of why it fits. The matched request is submitted directly to the clinic, which accepts, refers to a better-suited clinic, or declines, with the user notified of the outcome, required documents, and a named caseworker contact all within the platform.

Technically, Law Link runs as a single-page web application (React, Vite, Tailwind CSS) with a structured clinic directory built from real data from Start Right, Refugee Law Clinic München, and the Law Clinics Deutschland network. A lightweight persistent user identity links each session to a case record. The platform is fully bilingual in German and English.

Three groups benefit. Clients gain faster, less confusing access to free legal help they might otherwise give up trying to find. Clinics receive fewer misrouted inquiries and structured intake data with each request, significantly reducing manual triage. At the network level, Law Clinics Deutschland and Start Right gain a maintainable referral infrastructure that scales as clinics open, close, or shift specialisation turning ad hoc routing into a managed system.

Our go-to-market strategy reaches students first through channels they already trust such as university welcome and offer letters, faculty websites, student unions, and international student offices. Clinic partnerships with Start Right make Law Link the front door for the entire network, with natural expansion to NGOs and refugee centres as adoption grows.

4.Solution

The solution LawLink proposes does not focus on replacing human legal advice, but on structurally improving how people discover and access it. Instead of requiring users to select predefined categories that they might not understand, the platform introduces a interface that allows them to describe their situation in their own words. This distinction is critical: legal capability research consistently shows that individuals often lack the technical vocabulary and knowledge required to accurately categorise their own problems in strictly legal terms (Pleasence et al., 2014). Student law clinics already play an important role in providing free legal help to individuals and nonprofit organisations that cannot easily afford professional legal services (Bücker & Woodruff, 2008), but this support remains fragmented across legal areas, eligibility requirements, and local structures.

To bridge this gap and overcome the initial barrier of informational uncertainty, the system translates the user's open narrative into structured information through a process of adaptive questioning. This assessment is not static; it dynamically analyses and weighs critical factors such as geographical location and language. Based on this diagnosis, LawLink generates a tailored set of suitable student law clinic matches, accompanied by a transparent explanation of why each option is relevant to their specific situation. This methodological design reflects a paradigm shift in the digital access-to-justice landscape: the transition from simple static information provision to guided decision-making, an evolution increasingly recognised by experts as essential for the success of technology-driven legal aid solutions (Susskind, 2019).

The benefits of this approach are both practical and systemic. For users, LawLink reduces uncertainty, simplifies decision-making, and lowers the psychological and informational barriers associated with seeking legal help. For law clinics, it improves the quality of incoming requests by filtering and structuring information in advance, which is particularly valuable given that many clinics operate with limited resources and rely on volunteer work. From a broader perspective, the platform reduces search and transaction costs, which are known to be significant obstacles in accessing legal services (Cooter & Ulen, 2016). By improving the efficiency of the referral process, LawLink contributes to a more effective allocation of existing legal aid resources.

What constitutes the genuine novelty of LawLink is not the mere incorporation of artificial intelligence tools, but the philosophy and method with which this technology is applied to the legal referral process. Traditional solutions available on the market, such as static directories or purely informational websites, operate under the idealised assumption that citizens are capable of independently identifying the nature of their legal problem and comparing the intake requirements of different service providers. However, this assumption ignores the realities documented in social research, which particularly affect users with limited legal literacy, chronic language barriers, or a history of negative institutional experiences (OECD, 2019).

In response to this challenge, LawLink introduces an innovative hybrid approach that blends natural language interaction, rule-based institutional eligibility filtering, and transparent system recommendations. In doing so, the platform actively operationalises the theoretical concept of legal capability: it does not expect the user to decipher the justice system alone, but instead actively guides, supports, and empowers them as they navigate their own legal reality (Pleasence et al., 2014).

5. Search Engine Architecture

The proposed search engine follows a Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) architecture to provide accurate and context-aware responses. Instead of relying only on keyword matching, the system performs semantic search by understanding the meaning of the user's query and retrieving the most relevant information from the knowledge base.

When a user submits a query, it undergoes preprocessing, including text normalization, tokenization, and stop-word removal. The processed query is then converted into a vector embedding using a pre-trained embedding model. This embedding captures the semantic meaning of the query, allowing the system to identify relevant documents even when different wording is used.

All documents in the knowledge base are preprocessed and converted into vector embeddings during the indexing stage. These embeddings are stored in a vector database, enabling efficient similarity-based retrieval. At runtime, the query embedding is compared with the stored document embeddings using cosine similarity. Approximate Nearest Neighbor (ANN) indexing is employed to perform fast vector searches, making the system scalable for large document collections.

The search engine retrieves the top-k most relevant documents based on their similarity scores. These retrieved documents are then provided as contextual input to a Large Language Model (LLM). By grounding the response generation on retrieved information, the LLM produces answers that are more accurate, relevant, and less prone to hallucination than responses generated solely from the model's internal knowledge.

The overall workflow consists of four main stages: document indexing, query embedding, semantic retrieval, and response generation. This modular architecture allows each component, including the embedding model, vector database, retrieval algorithm, and LLM, to be updated independently as newer technologies become available. Additionally, caching frequently accessed embeddings and search results can further improve response times and reduce computational overhead. The combination of semantic search and generative AI enables the system to deliver fast, scalable, and context-aware information retrieval while maintaining high search accuracy.

6. Discussion & Outlook

The core value of LawLink is not to automate legal consultation, but to improve the navigation process before users enter the legal support system. Student law clinics provide free legal support, but this support does not automatically reach the people who need it. Many users do not know which legal field their problem belongs to, which law clinic is suitable for them, or whether they meet the consultation requirements. Therefore, LawLink aims to transform a vague and discouraging search process into a step-by-step, confirmable and explainable referral process. This follows the idea of people-centred access to justice, which starts from people's real problems and user experiences.

This aim shaped the design of LawLink. The platform does not ask users to deal with a complex list of law clinics from the beginning. Instead, users can first describe their problem in their own words. The system then asks follow-up questions about location, language, urgency, court representation and claim amount. Before the final match, users can review the system's understanding of the case, including the legal area, case details and eligibility factors. This review and correction step is important because AI may misunderstand legal problems, especially when descriptions are vague, multilingual or connected to several legal fields. Research on legal aid intake also argues that LLMs should not give an early "best guess", but should first ask for more context and user intention (Goodson & Lu, 2023). Therefore, AI in LawLink is mainly used to understand, clarify and structure information, not to replace legal judgement. Similar research shows that combining LLMs with rule-based logic can support civil legal services intake, but risks such as wrong matching or wrong exclusion still need to be controlled (Steenhuis & Westermann, 2024).

From the perspective of social sustainability, LawLink needs to respond to three groups: users, the platform and law clinics. For users, the key issue is privacy and agency. Legal problems may involve sensitive topics such as housing, migration, employment or debt. Therefore, the platform should follow data minimization and collect only the information needed for matching. It should also clearly explain which information will be shared with which clinic before a request is submitted (European Parliament and Council of the European Union, 2016). For the platform, the key issue is transparency and accountability. Since AI is involved in understanding the case and ranking matches, the result cannot be a black-box answer. It should explain the matching criteria, such as legal area, location, language, eligibility requirements, clinic notes and system confidence. If no exact match is found, the system should also communicate this limitation clearly instead of pretending that the problem has been solved. This is in line with trustworthy AI principles, which emphasize human-centred, transparent and responsible AI systems (National Institute of Standards and Technology, 2023; OECD, 2024). For law clinics, the key issue is fair visibility. A clinic should not receive less attention only because its website is incomplete, less digitalized or less clearly written. To reduce this bias, LawLink should use unified structured clinic profiles in the future. Clinics should be able to maintain their legal fields, target groups, languages, active status, requirements, exclusions and intake links through the same fields. Recommendations should be based on case-clinic fit, not on popularity, website quality or existing traffic. In this way, LawLink can avoid creating new referral inequality while trying to solve the user's navigation problem.

Trust-building also requires attention to different legal and cultural backgrounds. Users from different countries and social experiences may understand legal institutions, free consultation and data sharing differently. Some may see law as a tool for solving problems, while others may connect it with costs, bureaucracy, identity risks or mistrust. Research on legal consciousness shows that migration experiences, cultural dynamics, social relations and public policy can influence how people understand law and whether they seek legal help (Güdük & Desmet, 2022). Therefore, LawLink's explanation of law clinics, free support, service limits and data protection is not just additional information. It is a precondition for user trust and lowering the psychological barrier to asking for help.

In its future development, LawLink could possibly address not only functional improvements but also validation, governance, and effective user outreach. Rather than simply adding more AI functions, the next steps and long-term vision will focus on the following key areas:

- **Strategic Ecosystem Expansion & Outreach:** Since student law clinics are not widely known in Germany, a single independent website is insufficient.
 - **Short-term:** LawLink could be embedded as a referral widget or chatbot plug-in on the websites of various independent law clinics. If a user visits a clinic but their case falls outside its scope, the widget can seamlessly guide them to a more suitable contact point.
 - **Medium-term:** LawLink aims to cooperate with university international offices, student services, NGOs, tenant advice centres, and refugee support organizations, ensuring that access points appear on platforms that marginalized users already know and trust.
- **Continuous Validation & User-Centric Testing:** The platform's legal taxonomy, eligibility criteria, and matching rules must be rigorously and continuously tested in collaboration with the law clinics. Furthermore, the user interface and educational explanations should be tested with users from diverse linguistic, cultural, and legal backgrounds to ensure true accessibility and comprehension.
- **Robust Governance & Feedback Loops:** To transition from a prototype to a maintainable referral infrastructure, future versions must include a clinic-side update interface. This will allow clinics to autonomously update their own information, capacities, and requirements. Crucially, a feedback loop will be established so the platform can identify incorrect matches or unfair visibility patterns.
- **Ethical AI & Systemic Fairness:** The continuous data maintenance and feedback loops will not only be used for technical improvements but also to actively monitor whether certain legal needs or clinics are systematically underrepresented. By establishing ethical guardrails and strictly protecting user data, LawLink will ensure the matching algorithm remains unbiased and serves the community fairly.

Overall, LawLink does not advocate for “more AI automation,” but rather a more careful and responsible use of AI. AI supports users in expressing their problems, structuring information, and finding an initial match. However, the actual legal judgment, case acceptance, and consultation firmly remain within the human legal support system. The long-term significance of LawLink, therefore, is not just helping a single user find a single clinic. More importantly, it transforms a fragmented, unclear, and manually referred support system into an infrastructure that is visible, accessible, and easy to coordinate. In this sense, the connection between LawLink and sustainability is a concrete social goal: through transparent, careful, and human-centered design, existing legal support resources can reach the people who need them in a fairer way.

6. Author Contribution

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7.Literature

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